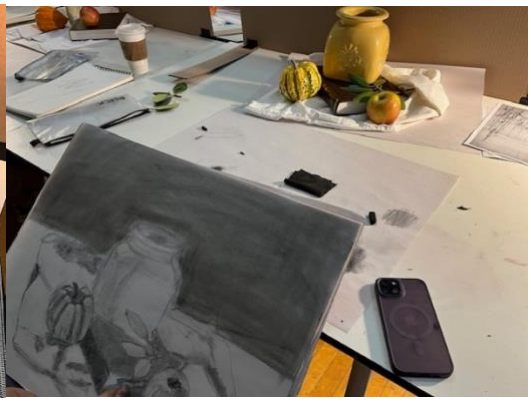
DRAWING I

Project: Drawing a Still Life from Observation.

The students progressed through the skills of seeing and drawing contour line, negative space, tonal value, perspective, and the gestalt of a picture. Charcoal was chosen for its expansive tonal range. Seeing is also interpreting, and so we analyzed historic and contemporary drawing to guide contextual thinking. The results are subtle, contemplative still life's, each one opening up the possibility for the expression of emotion through a visual form.



INTRO

I enjoy sharing my knowledge about art and inspiring others to be creative. Drawing is an exciting and rigorous activity, both conceptually and physically challenging. I see drawing as a fundamental skill, not only necessary to develop a unique artistic voice, but also unlock different ways of understanding the world.

DAY 1 CONTOUR

We covered an essential drawing idea during the first class. The "upside-down" drawing is designed to help you experience observation without judgement. To see forms without "preconceived ideas" interfering with your observations. This will be the approach we use throughout the class. This approach takes "mental toughness" and is not the default way we experience the world.

We also practiced the technique of "contour line" that describes volume. We employed time restraints to quicken decision making during sketching. Finally, we contemplated drawings by Ellsworth Kelly for examples of contour line. Kelly's non-dramatic graphite drawings balance

negative and positive space and allow one to focus on the highly specific edges of the object. These drawings convey meaning through the nature of the mark, its weight and rhythm and speed.

Next class we will continue contour drawing and begin drawing apples. We will also practice intuitive gestures as a means of arranging compositions. Remember to answer the question on the back of the Stravinsky drawing, read the hand out text, and complete one contour drawing of your hand.

DAY 2 APPLES

During our second class we explored the technique of “intuitive gesture” in which lightly applied lines create a quick, all-encompassing overview of forms and their relationship in space. This technique is a fluid process and should not be viewed as right or wrong, but as progressive stages of perceptual sensitivity. We also practiced drawing mechanics such as “drawing grip” and “correct posture” to help us sight measure.

For next class read and bring the Intuitive Gesture handout, complete the analysis questions for the Ellsworth Kelly Drawing, and create one “intuitive gesture” sketch of a piece of fruit in your sketch book.

DAY 3 APPLES

Last class began with a demonstration for tonal development. One begins at a single point on an object, moving out following the movements of your eye, and renders tonal shapes as they are apprehended. This approach was discussed in relation to the drawings of Paul Cezanne, who's ability to pay close attention to perception while constructing a "solid" form, allowed him to capture nature as he/we perceive it. “Painting from nature is not copying the object; it is realizing one's sensations.” - Paul Cezanne

For next class, please bring in the "Cezanne Analysis" and a sketch of a cup.

DAY 4 VASE

During our fourth class we added a vase to our list of still life objects. During the first part of class we utilized daylight to observe tonal subtly. As the sun set, we switched to incandescent light, creating more dramatic contrast. We continue to base our drawing on careful observation, but we also employed “ellipses” and “plumb lines” to provide symmetry. For the final part of class, we Interpreted Cezanne's drawing and asked culturally relevant questions during “art talk.”

Next class we welcome Pittsburgh artist and teacher Todd Keyser who will lecture about tonalist works and lead the class in an assignment titled “drawing with Ink.” Keyser has taught Exploring Drawing and was Director of the Harlan Gallery at Seton Hill University.

Please bring your assessments of the Morandi drawing. No sketchbook drawing is due.

DAY 5

We began class with a field trip to the Chatham Art Gallery, where artist Ashley Cecil presented some ideas of her work. Mrs. Cecil's work employs collage as a compositional tool, in which she arranges found images. We looked for elements of drawing in her paper works and asked questions about her inspiration and method. Once back to the drawing studio, visiting artist Todd Keyser gave a presentation on tonalist watercolor landscapes. Finally, we experimented with how graphite and Sumi ink can capture the effects of light and shadow. Please bring a sketch of fabric and the Morandi drawing analysis for next class.

DAY 6

In this class we began to render the fabric portion of the still life. This is the most demanding element in the arrangement as it relies completely on relational tonal areas. We also explored new materials such as heavy weight paper and compressed charcoal, as well as new techniques such as" reductive drawing" and utilizing the chamois for mid-tone. Please bring in your written analysis of the Seurat drawing and conte sketchbook copy. Next class we will continue the fabric studies and meet individually to review your work for midterm.

DAY 7

During our last class we concentrated on rendering fabric folds using a reductive method. Reductive drawing is building up areas of tone, then drawing with the erasure and compressed charcoal to create tonal value. We also did individual portfolio reviews, where we practiced articulating our thoughts about materials, techniques, and the aesthetic evaluation of our drawings. Everyone picked one work to be photographed and that could be displayed in the survey show. Finally, we reviewed a Morandi homework. As a group we discussed the forms within Morandi's etching, the effects they have on a viewer, and how the notion of subjectivity has changed in the modern era. Midterm grades were posted and emails were sent regarding work that needs to be completed related to any missed class.

DAY 8: COMPLEX STILL LIFE / MIDTERMS

During the last class we started our “complex still life” drawings. These drawings incorporate all the techniques and objects we have practiced thus far; organic lines (plant), tonal study (apple), symmetrical form (vase), and light and shadow (fabric). Portfolio reviews were also completed. Next class we will continue to draw the complex still life, along with the inclusion of liner and atmospheric perspective. Please answer the analysis questions for the Seurat drawing and the Giacometti drawing.

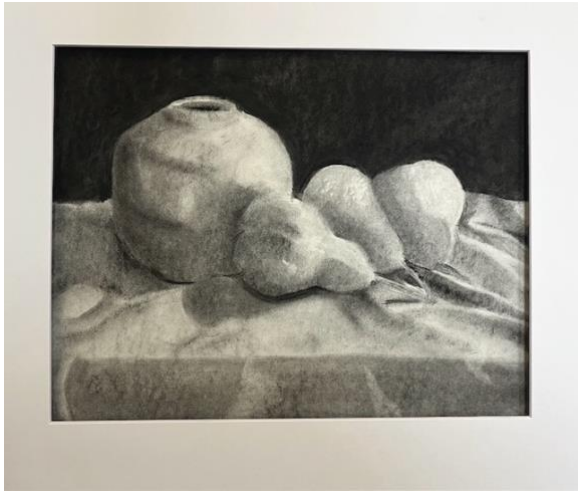
DAY 9: Perspective

During our last class we gathered as a group to interpret the Seurat and Giacometti drawings. We described the balanced composition of the Seurat drawing, and how his use of Conté crayon over textured paper created a sense of drama between light and shadow. This techniques imbued the image with a sense of inward orientation and contemplation. For the Giacometti drawing, we described the formal elements such as a messy foreground, a mid-ground with strange figures, and an empty background, and how perceiving these three areas created an unsettling feeling. Next we practiced two point and atmospheric perspective though rendering a book. We observed how rectangular objects can be represented with lines that coverage to a vanishing point shift to a lighter tone as they recede. We then employed these ideas in our complex still life.

DAY 10: Still life within a Frame.

Last class we began drawing a complex still life on heavy weight paper. This paper had been cut to 16 x 20 inches, a common frame size. Each paper was also given an inner pencil frame of 11 x 17 to provide a line where a matte would cover the drawing. We discussed that while our

drawings should never leave the room, (as they are about practice and growth) we also appreciate the benefit of hanging work up for others to see. A selection of works where installed in the display area of the art building. Today's still life's also incorporated a new platform to give a "trompe l'oeil" effect of depth and black backgrounds to create contrast and drama. Please complete your analysis of the Georgia O'Keeffe.



Day 11: Still Life (tonal)

We started this class with a review of the Georgia O'Keeffe drawing. After analyzing this work, we talked about the Bauhaus "foundation" art education model. Next we tried a Bauhaus drawing assignment ourselves, one designed to challenge you to respond to open-ended directions and search for visual solutions. Next we talked about the work from last class, during which we observed successful representational techniques and some areas to improve upon. We then set up our individual still life's and worked on creating a tonal representation, drawing back to front, building the image with tone against tone. Finally these works were installed on the display wall. For homework please review the "art terms" hand out.

DAY 12: Abstraction from organic objects

This class began with another Bauhaus inspired assignment, one meant to challenge students to think about how an organic object grows and what form can be identified within the objects growth pattern. This is an example of drawing that starts from observation and leaps into the realm of ideas. We picked out an organic object and made two quick sketches. Next we practiced abstract mark making and studied how they "speak" for themselves. Then in an act of synthesis, we attempt to put both these exercises together into a single drawing. Following this, we either set up a new still life or began drawing utilizing the easels in the paintings studio. The two new subjects being either a cluttered studio or a Memento Mori. Next class be prepare to discuss the vocabulary words and the Vanitas still life.

DAY 13: Complex Still Life final

For class today we discussed the Vanitas painting handout and continued to work on our complex still life drawings as well as explore what it like to use the easels for a perspectival and a vanitas drawing. A 30 min slide lecture was given providing "context" for the history of the still life, from Ancient Greece to modern times. Please analysis the Chardin painting and read the Sublime and Uncanny handout for next class. Next class we will be joined by artist August Vollbrecht, who will talk about her practice of drawing.

DAY 14: NO CLASS HOLIDAY

DAY 15: Complex Still Life with guest artist August Vollbrecht

For class today we continued to draw our complex still life. Visiting artist August Vollbrecht presented her painting practice in a slide show. She also installed a set of charcoal drawings to demonstrated her sketching process. She answered questions about her work and demonstrated for the class her approach to drawing. In the demonstration she described how she draws "the entire picture" and looks for "the best mark" to express the object. She then provided feedback for each student. Past artworks were returned and our drawings were installed for Survey. Survey takes place Thursday, December 12, with refreshments in the late afternoon, between 4 PM-6 PM**.** Please stop by to see all the art and then take home your still life drawing. Review the Sublime/Uncanny handout and analyze the Chardin still life for next class. The final class will include a final drawing, a review of the course, and a presentation of my painting practice. Please review your grades and turn in any late assignments.

Day 16: Reductive Drawing of Complex Still Life / Artist Presentation by Peter Mandradjieff

For the final class we created a reductive charcoal drawing. First a small amount a tact powder was rubbed into the surface of the paper to allow for ease of erasure. Next compressed charcoal was applied in skeins to create a mid-tone grey. Then we drew by erasing and using the chamois to remove charcoal and create tonal variations. These images often produce an illusion of volume with the objects recede into the black background.

Following this we reviewed the ideas of the sublime and uncanny. We looked at a Caspar David Friedrich painting for an example of the sublime, which is a sense of uplift and aesthetic pleasure found in a dangerous and disturbing event or object. You feel small in the face of this immensity, and this creates a "self-forgetting" that becomes a pleasurable experience. Think of looking at large waterfall or a storm cloud over the ocean. We next looked at Magritte painting as an example of the uncanny, which is a response to something familiar that is unsettling and disturbing. Think of any representation of a ghost in a picture or seeing your double on the street. This is a response to a part of the psyche that has been repressed, but has returned briefly to unsettle your understanding of the world. After this, as a group we analyzed the

Chardin painting. We talked about the strong sense of materiality in the image, and how that influenced on modern art.

I did a presentation of my own painting practice, showing a set of influences from the photography of Robert Adams and the paintings of Agnes Martin and how my paintings attempt to create an object to engage with a contradiction between graphic clarity and spatial illusion, to provoke a feeling of the sublime. We also reviewed each assignment, as a quick review of the class. Finally, I spoke about the benefits of studying drawing and the humanities. I argued that drawing requires you to think “holistically” about the world around you and the complex nature of perception. Only with the humanities are you asked to “earn your beliefs” and this demand creates personal responsibility, moving you from a “consumer” mindset into a “maker” mindset. For “ungraded” homework, please frame one of your drawings and hang it up, travel to the Carnegie Museum of Art and view the “Glass of Water and Coffeepot” by Chardin, and continue to draw in your free time.